

The Prescott Girls – Study Guide

Letters and Communication in the 1830s

Sharing News Before Telephones

In the early nineteenth century, people did not have telephones, email, or instant messaging. Most communication over long distances took place through **letters carried by the postal system**.

Writing letters was an important way for friends and family members to stay connected. News about births, deaths, travel, business, and politics often traveled slowly from one town to another through handwritten correspondence.

For many people, receiving a letter was an important event that brought news from the outside world.



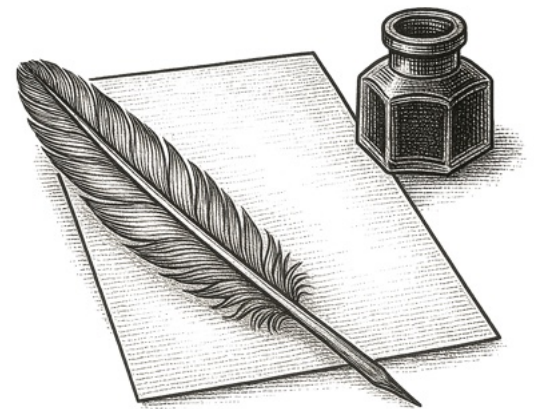
Writing Letters

During the 1830s, letters were usually written using **pen and ink** on paper.

Writers often followed a common format that included:

- the date and location
- a greeting to the person receiving the letter
- the main message
- a closing phrase
- the writer's signature

Because paper and postage could be expensive, people often wrote carefully and tried to fit as much information as possible into a single letter.



The Postal System

By the early 1800s, the United States had developed a growing postal network that connected towns across the country.

Mail traveled along **postal routes** using:

- horseback riders
- stagecoaches
- wagons
- boats along rivers and coastal waters

Local post offices served as important community centers where people could send and receive mail.



Even so, letters could take **days or weeks** to arrive depending on distance and weather.

Letters and New Ideas

Letters were not only used for personal news. They also helped spread ideas.

People shared:

- news about political events
- religious discussions
- reform movements
- pamphlets and printed materials

In the early nineteenth century, letters helped spread discussions about issues such as education, social reform, and slavery.

Because newspapers and books were not always easy to obtain, letters often carried important information between towns and cities.



Connections to *The Prescott Girls*

In *The Prescott Girls*, letters play an important role in connecting people who live far apart.

Friends and relatives often exchanged letters to share news and ideas. Through these letters, people in small towns could learn about events happening in larger cities such as Philadelphia.

Letters helped families stay connected and allowed new ideas to travel from place to place.

Why This History Matters

Studying how people communicated in the past helps us understand how information once traveled across long distances. In the early nineteenth century, letters were one of the most important ways people stayed connected with friends, relatives, and communities far away.

Unlike today, when messages can be sent instantly, communication in the 1830s required patience and careful writing. A letter might travel for days or even weeks before reaching its destination, depending on the distance and the conditions of the roads or rivers. Because letters took time to arrive, writers often included many different pieces of news in a single message.

These written messages helped connect families and friends and played an important role in shaping conversations about important issues of the time. By reading letters from the past, historians can learn how people thought, what they cared about, and how communities stayed connected long before modern communication existed.



Questions for Discussion

1. Why were letters an important way for people to communicate in the 1830s?
2. What kinds of news might people include in their letters?
3. Why might it take a long time for a letter to arrive?
4. How is communication today different from communication in the 1830s?
5. Why might people have saved letters for many years?

Activity

Imagine you are living in Maine in the 1830s and writing a letter to a friend in another town.

Write a short letter describing:

- what your daily life is like
- something happening in your community
- a question you would like to ask your friend

Remember to include the date, a greeting, and a closing.